

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Overusing mirrors until the conversation feels mechanical, tactical, or suspicious.

CORE FORMULA

Key phrase + curious tone + pause. -> Key phrase -> curious tone -> pause -> let them expand -> choose your next move. -> "I'm not sure it's workable." -> "Workable?" -> (pause) -> "The price is too high." -> "High?" -> (pause) -> "It got a bit messy." -> "Messy?" -> (pause)

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Mirror one to three words, then pause.

BEST FOR

- Keeping someone talking without asking a full question.
- Negotiation, objections and uncertainty.
- When someone uses a vague but important phrase.
- When you need more detail before responding.
- When the conversation is moving too quickly.
- When someone hints at the real issue but does not fully explain it.
- When you want to sound interested without sounding intense.

PHRASE BANK

Quick mirrors · Short one-word echoes

- "Too much?"
- "Risky?"
- "Not worth it?"
- "The timing?"
- "A bit off?"
- "The people side?"
- "Not sure?"

Warm mirrors · Softer, feeling-aware echoes

- "That part mattered?"
- "A lot to carry?"
- "A bit disappointing?"
- "Harder than expected?"
- "More complicated?"
- "Still on your mind?"

Professional · Work, meetings, decisions

- "The main blocker?"
- "A resourcing issue?"
- "The decision criteria?"
- "The implementation risk?"
- "The timeline?"
- "The dependency?"

Negotiation / objection · Objections and pressure

- "Too expensive?"
- "Not enough certainty?"
- "The deadline?"

- "The trade-off?"
- "Approval from them?"
- "The number?"

Conflict-softening · Grievances, de-escalation

- "Disrespected?"
- "Not consulted?"
- "The way it happened?"
- "Felt sprung on you?"
- "The fairness piece?"
- "Blindsided?"

Social / dating · Light, playful rapport

- "Chaotic?"
- "Good weird?"
- "The short version?"
- "Your kind of thing?"
- "A lot going on?"
- "Good chaotic?"

Digital / text · Short replies, no stacking

- "Too soon?"
- "Worth doing?"
- "The timing?"
- "That part?"
- "What changed?"
- "Still deciding?"

High-status / busy · Brief, decision-focused

- "The key risk?"
- "Timing?"
- "The constraint?"
- "Priority?"
- "Decision rights?"
- "The real blocker?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the technique mechanically or too often.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version and then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts based on the response.
2. Weak: Echoes with a flat or sceptical tone.
Better: Echoes with a plain, neutral tone.
Best: Echoes with genuine curiosity, so it invites rather than challenges.
3. Weak: Talks about the technique instead of doing it.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.
Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary skilled conversation.

DECISION TREE

If They elaborate

Listen fully, then reflect or summarise the new detail.

"So it's less the concept, more the timing and who'd own it."

If They correct you

Accept the correction and fold it in.

"Got it - so it's more about ownership than the idea itself."

If They look confused

Translate the mirror into a plain question.

"Sorry - I meant, what part of the timing worries you?"

If They seem mocked

Repair immediately and clarify your intent.

"I wasn't challenging you - I just wanted to get the bit that matters."

If They give a short answer

Stop mirroring; comment or shift depth.

"Fair enough. Here's where I've landed on it."

If They become emotional

Move from mirror to validation or labelling.

"That sounds like it really stung."

If They ask what you think

Answer directly, then check you understood first.

"Happy to say - but first, have I got the concern right?"

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Echo the emotionally loaded word and let them unpack it. — "Weirdly intense?"

Workplace influence

Mirror the worry, then listen for the operational risk. — "The rollout?"

Negotiation

Mirror the objection and pause before defending anything. — "High?"

Conflict

Mirror the grievance, then validate once they expand. — "Left out?"

Digital / text

Send the mirror as a short reply - no stacked questions. — "The timing?"

Shy or guarded person

Use a softer mirror and offer an easy exit. — "A bit much? No pressure if you'd rather not get into it."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You have already mirrored several times in the same conversation.
- They are distressed and need validation more than a prompt.
- Your tone might sound sarcastic, mocking or suspicious.
- They are giving very short answers and seem pressured.
- The phrase is trivial and not worth following.
- A direct answer, apology, boundary or action is needed instead.
- You are using it to avoid giving your own view when they need clarity.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the loaded word

In three conversations, silently pick the single word or phrase carrying the most weight. Don't mirror yet - just notice what you'd echo if you did.

Day 2 — Mirror once

In three conversations, mirror one meaningful phrase a single time, then stop. Notice whether the person expands, corrects, or warms up.

Day 3 — Master the pause

After each mirror today, hold two full beats of silence before you say anything else. Let them fill the space instead of you.

Day 4 — Tune the tone

Practise one mirror ("The timing?") aloud three ways - flat, sceptical, and genuinely curious. Keep only the curious version and use it live.

Day 5 — Mirror an objection

In a disagreement or negotiation, mirror the objection instead of defending. Watch what the real concern turns out to be once they explain.

Day 6 — Recover cleanly

When a mirror lands awkwardly, practise one repair line - "I wasn't challenging that, I just wanted the bit that matters" - and carry on normally.

Day 7 — Know when to stop

Cap yourself at one or two mirrors per conversation all day, then deliberately switch to reflection, validation, or a direct answer.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use the technique because the cue was present, or because I wanted to perform skill?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Did the person have more room after my move, or less?
- Did I adjust if they became closed, pressured or confused?
- What neighbouring technique would have been better if this one missed?